



favour, allowing it to avoid a likely defeat at the hands of the vastly superior Tractor FC. Citing the volatile situation in Iran, it submitted a letter to the AFC, signed by its players who felt unsafe travelling to Tabriz, East Azerbaijan, the home of Tractor.

Having previously played a lacklustre goalless draw at home against arguably the weakest team in the group, Ravshan Kulob of Tajikistan, Mohun Bagan's intentions became apparent before the deteriorating geopolitical scenario in West Asia allowed it to abandon ship. In its decision, the AFC competition committee accepted Mohun Bagan's appeal as an "event of force majeure" and refrained from penalising the team. However, the AFC committee removed the team from the competition, citing ACL 2 regulations.

While Mohun Bagan opted out, the AFC Challenge League (a tier-three tournament below ACL 2) offered East Bengal a chance to redeem itself. Despite losing all six of its ISL matches, East Bengal

Silver lining: East Bengal earning a spot in the quarterfinals of the AFC Challenge League would have mitigated some of the disappointment of a poor start to the domestic season. *ISL*

ISL



notched up two wins and a draw to emerge as the Group A league champion in the AFC Challenge League, thus earning a spot in the quarterfinals. This definitely helped East Bengal mitigate some of the disappointment of a poor start to the domestic season, which ultimately led to the early departure of its coach Carles Cuadrat, under whose guidance the team won the Super Cup to secure its place in the AFC tournament.

With the appointment of another Spaniard, Oscar Bruzon (**left**), to guide the team through the remainder of the season, East Bengal is hoping to turn things around by building on its recent performance in the AFC Challenge League.

Amitabha Das Sharma

Of chingri, dhak and goals

In the city's football circuit, the beautiful game welcomed Pujo in its own way. Despite heavy rain before the match and the sky frowning with grey clouds, thousands turned up for the game. "I have been supporting the